

CARPENTERS FOR HOUSING REFORM VICTORIA

Registered Residential Carpenter (RRC) Pathway

Consultation Package - Version 2

A controlled pilot proposal for residential renovation work in Victoria

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Contents

1. Executive Summary
2. Why This Reform Is Being Considered
3. Alignment with Victorian Building Reform Priorities
4. The Renovation Grey Zone
5. The \$10,000 Threshold Problem
6. Hidden-Condition Escalation
7. Evidence Themes from Renovation Practice
8. Proposed RRC Pathway
9. Safeguards and Scope Limits
10. Controlled Pilot Model
11. Stakeholder Consultation Questions
12. Closing Position and Next Steps
13. Source Context

Purpose of this package

This Version 2 package expands on the 2-page RRC Executive Brief. It is intended to support discussion with government, regulators, builders, carpenters, insurers, consumer representatives and housing-sector stakeholders. It is not a final legislative proposal. It is a consultation-ready reform option.

1. Executive Summary

The Registered Residential Carpenter (RRC) pathway is a proposed controlled pilot pathway for experienced residential renovation carpenters in Victoria. It responds to a practical gap in domestic renovation work, where real projects often sit between minor trade work and full domestic building responsibility.

The proposal does not seek to replace registered builders, weaken regulation, or create an unlimited builder licence. It proposes a defined and accountable pathway for experienced renovation carpenters working within clear limits, supported by consumer disclosure, insurance requirements, documentation standards, permit and engineering triggers, and handover rules where a registered builder is required.

The pathway is being developed as a consumer-protection and role-clarity reform. Its purpose is to improve how the system deals with renovation realities including hidden damage, escalating scope, the \$10,000 threshold, consumer confusion, and the practical difference between new construction and repair or renovation work.

Core position

This reform strengthens the system - it does not bypass it.

The preferred implementation model is a controlled pilot program. A pilot would allow government, regulators, insurers, builders, carpenters and consumer representatives to test the pathway before any permanent change is considered.

The problem

Modern renovation work can become unclear when modest repairs reveal hidden structural damage or when material and labour costs exceed threshold settings.

The proposal

A limited-scope RRC pathway for experienced renovation carpenters with defined work limits and safeguards.

The safeguard principle

Consumer protection is strengthened through disclosure, documentation, insurance, scope limits and escalation triggers.

The pilot principle

Test the model carefully before permanent reform is considered.

2. Why This Reform Is Being Considered

Residential renovation work is different from new construction. The full condition of an existing home is often unknown until work begins. Walls, floors, decks, cladding, bathrooms, windows, subfloors and old repairs can reveal damage only after opening-up.

In practice, a homeowner may call a carpenter for what appears to be a limited repair. Once work starts, the job may reveal termite damage, dry rot, water damage, asbestos, non-compliant historical work, structural deterioration, ventilation failure or framing issues. The original scope may no longer reflect the actual work required to make the home safe and complete.

This creates a practical regulatory question: what should the law, the homeowner and the practitioner expect to happen when legitimate renovation work escalates because hidden conditions are discovered?

- Consumers may not understand when a carpenter, registered builder, building permit, engineer or insurer needs to be involved.
- Experienced renovation carpenters may have the practical skill to identify and manage certain work, but lack a clearly defined registration pathway for that middle ground.
- Builders remain essential for full domestic building responsibility, new homes and higher-risk work, but smaller and medium renovation work needs clearer role boundaries.
- The existing threshold can create uncertainty when real project scope is progressively revealed rather than fully known at the start.

Reform question

Can Victoria test a controlled, limited-scope pathway that improves consumer protection and clarity without weakening the registered builder system?

3. Alignment with Victorian Building Reform Priorities

The RRC pathway aligns with current Victorian building-system priorities: consumer protection, practitioner accountability, clearer regulatory roles, stronger oversight, dispute prevention and improved confidence in domestic building work.

Victoria already regulates building practitioners through categories and classes of registration, and current public guidance recognises defined scopes of lawful work. The RRC pathway should be understood in that context: not as an unlimited builder licence, but as a possible limited-scope registration pathway for a clearly defined renovation role.

Consumer protection

Clearer disclosure, documentation and escalation rules can help homeowners understand risk before and during renovation work.

Practitioner accountability

Registration, insurance, evidence requirements and scope limits can make responsibility clearer.

Role clarity

A defined pathway can help clarify where carpenter responsibility ends and where a registered builder, engineer or permit process is required.

Regulatory confidence

A pilot allows evidence to be gathered before permanent change is considered.

The proposal also aligns with the logic of limited and conditioned scopes. Victoria already recognises that not all practitioners operate across the same scope of work. A carefully designed RRC pilot could test whether renovation carpentry work can be better categorised, limited and supervised within the broader regulatory framework.

Alignment statement

The RRC pathway should be framed as a practical contribution to consumer protection, registration clarity and domestic renovation oversight.

4. The Renovation Grey Zone

The renovation grey zone exists where practical renovation carpentry work is more complex than minor trade work, but not the same as full builder-led domestic building work. This is common in older homes and repair-based projects.

Examples include bathrooms where wall and floor framing are only assessable after demolition, decks where structural condition is hidden below the boards, cladding jobs that reveal asbestos or rot, window replacements that become whole-house energy upgrades, and subfloor repairs where ventilation failure has caused extensive dry rot.

Consumers often engage the person they trust to solve the immediate problem. They may not know which legal role is required until the problem is opened up. This can leave the homeowner, carpenter and builder system without a simple pathway for staged assessment, documentation, escalation and handover.

Homeowners often begin with a visible repair or upgrade request.	Clear initial disclosure of scope, limits and escalation triggers.
Hidden damage may change the cost and nature of the job.	Photographic evidence, written variation advice and defined pause points.
Carpenter and builder responsibilities can become unclear.	Defined handover rules where builder, engineer or permit involvement is required.
The consumer may not understand the regulatory pathway.	Plain-English consumer guidance and mandatory documentation.

5. The \$10,000 Threshold Problem

Current public guidance in Victoria refers to registration and major domestic building contract requirements around domestic building work above \$10,000, with separate insurance obligations for higher-value work. This threshold remains an important regulatory marker, but modern renovation costs can reach it quickly.

The issue is not simply the dollar amount. The deeper issue is that renovation work is often progressively revealed. A project may appear modest at the quote stage, then change when hidden conditions are exposed. The law needs clear expectations for what happens when a genuine repair becomes a larger safety or compliance issue.

- Materials, subcontractor costs, compliance expectations and labour costs can cause modest renovation work to exceed the threshold quickly.
- Older homes commonly reveal hidden damage only after demolition or opening-up.
- Consumers may approve staged work without understanding when contract, insurance, permit or registration issues arise.
- A fixed upfront threshold is harder to apply cleanly when the true scope is not knowable at the start.

Threshold reform principle

The RRC pathway does not remove threshold protections. It seeks clearer rules for staged assessment, documentation, escalation and consumer disclosure when renovation work crosses practical or legal boundaries.

6. Hidden-Condition Escalation

Hidden-condition escalation is one of the strongest practical reasons for considering a limited RRC pathway. Existing homes can conceal damage and non-compliance inside walls, floors, roof spaces, decks, wet areas and cladding.

Once a hidden condition is revealed, the practitioner and homeowner face immediate decisions: whether to stop, make safe, document, notify, refer to an engineer or surveyor, bring in a registered builder, or vary the scope. Without clear rules, the situation can become confusing and risky.

Termite and dry rot

Visible damage may indicate a much larger concealed problem affecting studs, joists, bearers, rafters or subfloors.

Bathrooms and wet areas

Demolition can reveal rotten framing, out-of-level floors, non-compliant past work or structural support issues.

Decks and external work

Decking boards may hide unsafe framing, poor drainage, rot, unstable footings or non-compliant previous repairs.

Cladding and windows

External upgrades can reveal asbestos, poor insulation, water damage, framing defects or old non-compliant work.

An RRC pilot could test formal escalation rules, including photographic evidence, written homeowner updates, defined pause points, referral triggers and handover rules.

Escalation principle

The goal is not to let carpenters do everything. The goal is to define what must happen when renovation work reveals risk.

7. Evidence Themes from Renovation Practice

The reform is grounded in practical renovation experience. The following evidence themes should be developed over time through case studies, photographs, project notes, homeowner examples and consultation feedback.

Concealed termite damage and dry rot	Shows why initial visual inspection cannot always determine true scope.
Subfloor failure and ventilation issues	Shows how small visible defects can indicate large hidden structural problems.
Bathroom demolition and framing repair	Shows how wet-area work can quickly shift from finishing work to structural repair.
Cladding replacement and asbestos discovery	Shows why external upgrades can trigger safety, compliance and specialist involvement.
Window and energy-efficiency upgrades	Shows how whole-home improvements can exceed threshold levels through materials alone.
Consumer confusion around roles	Shows why clearer public guidance is needed between carpenter, builder, engineer and permit pathways.

Future versions of this package should include a structured evidence appendix with photos, project context, initial scope, discovered conditions, cost escalation, compliance triggers and lessons for reform design.

8. Proposed RRC Pathway

The proposed RRC pathway would create a limited and accountable registration pathway for experienced residential renovation carpenters. The pathway would recognise practical renovation experience while maintaining strong scope boundaries and regulatory oversight.

A possible model could require a recognised carpentry qualification, significant verified renovation experience, evidence of prior work, references, knowledge of domestic building obligations, insurance eligibility and completion of a practical assessment or panel review.

Who it is for

Experienced renovation carpenters with proven residential repair and renovation capability.

What it covers

Defined renovation, repair and improvement work within approved scope limits and safeguards.

What it does not cover

New home construction, full domestic building responsibility, multi-unit development or major work outside defined limits.

How it is controlled

Scope limits, documentation rules, insurance, consumer disclosure, and builder/engineer/surveyor handover triggers.

The pathway should be designed with regulators, builders, insurers and consumer representatives. It should not be written only by carpenters. Its credibility depends on balanced safeguards.

Design principle

The RRC pathway should sit between minor trade work and full registered domestic builder responsibility. It should create clarity, not confusion.

9. Safeguards and Scope Limits

The credibility of the RRC pathway depends on safeguards. Any pilot should be designed so that consumers are better protected than they are in the current grey zone.

Defined scope of work	Make clear what RRC practitioners can and cannot undertake.
Consumer disclosure	Explain role limits, escalation triggers, insurance and when other practitioners may be needed.
Insurance requirements	Ensure appropriate cover is available and connected to the approved work scope.
Photographic documentation	Create evidence of existing conditions, hidden damage and decision points.
Written variations and pause points	Prevent uncontrolled scope creep and document homeowner decisions.
Permit and engineering triggers	Require referral where the work reaches legal or technical thresholds.
Registered builder handover rules	Protect the role of registered builders and prevent inappropriate expansion of RRC scope.
Complaint and audit pathway	Allow oversight and continuous improvement during the pilot.

Non-negotiable boundary

The RRC pathway must not become an informal substitute for a registered builder licence. It should be limited, auditable and designed around consumer protection.

10. Controlled Pilot Model

A controlled pilot is the preferred pathway because it allows the concept to be tested without rushing permanent reform. It creates a safe way to examine whether the model improves clarity, accountability and consumer outcomes.

A pilot could run in a defined region, for a defined period, with a limited number of approved practitioners and clear reporting requirements. The scope could be conservative at first, then reviewed based on evidence.

Pilot participants

Experienced renovation carpenters who meet qualification, experience, insurance and assessment requirements.

Pilot oversight

Government, regulator, insurer, builder, consumer and industry representation.

Pilot measures

Consumer outcomes, complaints, insurance events, documentation quality, referrals, handovers and scope compliance.

Pilot review

Independent assessment before expansion, change or permanent adoption is considered.

The pilot should be designed to answer practical questions: does the pathway reduce confusion, improve documentation, support proper handover, protect consumers and preserve the role of registered builders?

Pilot principle

Test, measure, review, then decide. The RRC pathway should earn confidence through evidence.

11. Stakeholder Consultation Questions

The following questions are designed to support constructive consultation rather than advocacy alone. They invite feedback on risk, scope, safeguards and implementation.

- Do stakeholders agree that a practical grey zone exists between minor renovation carpentry and full domestic builder responsibility?
- Do consumers clearly understand when they need a carpenter, a registered builder, a building permit, an engineer or domestic building insurance?
- Does the current \$10,000 threshold reflect modern renovation costs and hidden-condition escalation?
- What work, if any, could safely sit within a limited RRC scope?
- Which work should remain outside RRC scope and require a registered builder or other practitioner?
- What qualifications, experience and assessment should be required before an RRC practitioner is approved?
- What insurance, documentation and disclosure requirements would be necessary?
- What mandatory pause points or handover triggers should apply when hidden damage is discovered?
- Would a controlled pilot be an appropriate way to test the model before permanent reform is considered?
- What would be the biggest risk or objection from the perspective of consumers, builders, insurers and regulators?

Consultation aim

The goal is not to prove a predetermined answer. The goal is to test whether a safer, clearer and more accountable renovation pathway is possible.

12. Closing Position and Next Steps

The Registered Residential Carpenter pathway is a practical reform option for discussion. It recognises that modern renovation work often sits between minor trade work and full domestic building responsibility, especially when hidden conditions are discovered after work begins.

The proposal is strongest when framed as a consumer-protection, role-clarity and accountability reform. It should not be presented as a trade entitlement or as a way to avoid builders. Builders remain essential to the building system. The RRC pathway would only be credible if it is limited, insured, documented, auditable and supported by clear handover triggers.

The next step is structured consultation. This includes feedback from government, the Building and Plumbing Commission, building surveyors, registered builders, insurers, consumer representatives, experienced carpenters, housing policy stakeholders and homeowners.

The preferred pathway is a controlled pilot. A pilot would allow the model to be tested carefully and measured against consumer protection, complaint outcomes, documentation standards, scope compliance and system clarity.

Final statement

This reform strengthens the system - it does not bypass it.

Website: www.carpentryreform.com.au

Executive Brief: RRC_Executive_Brief_Victoria_2026.pdf

Consultation Package: RRC_Consultation_Package_Website_V2.pdf

13. Source Context

This proposal is informed by current public Victorian guidance and regulatory context. The sources below provide context only; they do not indicate endorsement of the RRC proposal.

Consumer Affairs Victoria - Becoming a registered building practitioner

Public guidance states that practitioners must register with the BPC for domestic building in Victoria when handling work over \$10,000, and for reblocking, restumping, demolishing or removing a home regardless of value.

<https://www.consumer.vic.gov.au/licensing-and-registration/builders-and-tradespeople/becoming-a-registered-building-practitioner>

Consumer Affairs Victoria - Domestic building contracts

Public guidance refers to major domestic building contracts for work worth more than \$10,000 and domestic building insurance obligations for work worth more than \$16,000.

<https://www.consumer.vic.gov.au/licensing-and-registration/builders-and-tradespeople/running-your-business/domestic-building-contract/s/what-work-requires-a-building-contract>

Victorian Building Authority - Building practitioner registration

Public guidance states the BPC regulates the building industry in Victoria and registers practitioners across categories and classes, each with specific scope and requirements.

<https://www.vba.vic.gov.au/registration-and-licensing/building-practitioner-registration>

Victorian Building Authority - Domestic Builder

Public guidance notes the BPC accepts Domestic Builder (Unlimited) applications with conditions that restrict scope of works, showing that restricted scope is part of the existing regulatory logic.

<https://www.vba.vic.gov.au/registration-and-licensing/building-practitioner-registration/domestic-builder>

Building and Plumbing Commission - About and role

The BPC describes its role as simplifying the system, strengthening consumer protections, supporting practitioners and upholding confidence and integrity across the industry.

<https://www.bpc.vic.gov.au/>

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